

VERSION COMPATIBILITY IN VASL AS OF JULY 2025



Purpose

This document describes version compatibility between different VASL versions, covering both the core VASL module (the .vmod file) and extensions (.vmdx files).

It does not deal with compatibility between VASL and VASSAL versions which are described on the modules page of VASL.info: <https://vasl.info/download.htm>.

For the purposes of this document, compatibility has two dimensions: (1) feature functionality and (2) counter appearance.

IMPORTANT: Compatibility Advice

Games should be started and finished with the same VASL version.

Both players should use the same version of VASL when playing.

Keep multiple versions of both VASSAL and VASL installed for ease of compatibility. See “Multiple VASL versions” below.

VASL version-to-version compatibility

Generally speaking, VASL modules (.vmod files) are designed to be forward compatible. That is, features contained in previous versions will continue to work in the new module (unless specifically changed or removed). As a result, games saved (.vsav files) in previous versions should open in newer versions with full feature functionality and all counters visible.

There is one important exception to the above. New feature functionality that is added into counters in the new version will not be available on counters used in a game saved in a previous version. Simply saving such a game in the new version will not add the functionality. The counters must be replaced with new versions, either by dragging them from the counter palette or by using the Game Update tool (see below).

For example, in VASL6.6.8, shaders such as Night did not persist when saving a game and had to be reset each time the .vsav was opened. Persistence was added in VASL6.6.9. However, opening a game saved in 6.6.8 in VASL6.6.9 would not persist the shader. The shader has to be added again and then, once the game is saved in 6.6.9, it will persist when it is re-opened in 6.6.9 or later versions.

VASL6.6.9 also added a new “BH & HC” option to the HOB menu for appropriate units. Opening a game saved in 6.6.8 in 6.6.9 does not add this item to the HOB menu. Nor does saving the game in 6.6.9. It is necessary to either replace the existing counter with one of the same type from the counter palette in 6.6.9 or to use the Game Update tool to replace the counter.

VASL is not designed for backward compatibility. Saved games should not be opened using earlier versions of VASL.

Using the previous example, if a game is saved in 6.6.9 with the night shader enabled, opening that game in 6.6.8 will not display the night shader, it would have to be reset and will not persist. There is some evidence that counter-based functionality may be backward compatible to a degree. For example, opening a game saved in 6.6.9 with 6.6.8 will still display the “BH & HC” menu item on appropriate counters. This apparent backward compatibility has not been rigorously tested and there is no reason to expect it to work in all circumstances.

VASL and SVG Compatibility

VASL6.7.0 introduced the widespread use of SVG graphics to display counter images. At present, this has no impact on VASL version-to-version compatibility. Counter images in games created in 6.6.10 and earlier will display properly when opened in 6.7.0 and beyond.

NOTE: this will change in the future once SVG graphics are fully implemented and debugged.

SVG graphics are not backward compatible and will not display in VASL versions earlier than 6.7.0. Games saved in 6.7.0 and beyond should not be opened in 6.6.10 and earlier.

Extensions

At present, extension compatibility is identical to VASL version compatibility as described above.

This will start to change as SVG-based versions of extensions are produced. These versions will only work with games created in 6.7.0 and beyond. For example, the Nationality Smoke extension has already been converted to SVG graphics and, as a result, if loaded by VASL6.6.10 or earlier, will not display the smoke images. To address this issue, before converting extensions to SVG, developers should first save the existing extension with the same filename plus “ gifpng”. For example, the Nationality Smoke extension should be saved with the filename “Nationality Smoke gifpng.vmdx”. This approach will allow the work on auto-syncing for extensions to proceed.

Not all extensions will get updated to use SVG graphics as they simply don’t require them. These extensions will continue to work as they currently do.

For the next while it will be possible, and perhaps advisable, to install two versions of some extensions, the “SVG” version and the “PNG/GIF” version, distinguishable by filename. At some point in the future, once SVG graphics are fully implemented and debugged, it should be possible to remove all of the “gifpng” versions.

To make this clear to users, the Extensions page on VASL.info will be revamped shortly to create a new block for extensions with svg images, maintain the block of current V6 extensions which will contain

GIF/PNG images, and remove just about all of the 5.X extensions from the page. Those that are worth keeping and still work with recent VASL versions will be moved to the V6 section.

Game Update Tool

The Game Update tool was introduced in version 6.6.7 and more detailed information is available under Help in VASL.

To update all counters in an older saved game to the new functionality of the current VASL version being used, use the Game Update tool.

NOTE: Currently the Game Update Tool does not work properly with SVG graphics and should not be used in VASL6.7.0 and beyond until a fix is implemented.

Auto-Syncing

Currently, extensions do not auto-sync in the same way that boards and overlays do. Work is underway to enable auto-syncing.

Multiple versions of VASL installed

It is possible to have multiple versions of VASL and VASSAL installed on a device at the same time.

For VASL, simply download all the desired VASL versions from VASL.info and place them in a single directory/folder.

For VASSAL, download the VASSAL version desired and double click the file to begin the installation process. At the Standard/Custom install screen, select Custom and don't select any previous versions to be removed. Continue with the install and all previous versions will remain available.

Preferences set in VASL/VASSAL remain the same across all of the installed versions. Preferences (for example, die colours) introduced in a particular version of VASL or VASSAL will not have effect in earlier versions.